The Open Society Funding Network in South Africa

How OSF, Omidyar/Luminate and USAID fund overlapping parts of South Africa's civil-society infrastructure. Sometimes independently. Sometimes through shared recipients. In several cases through shared or pooled funding programmes.

This investigation documents co-funding, common vehicles and overlapping recipient institutions. It does not argue that OSF, Omidyar/Luminate and USAID are one organisation or operate under common control.

$238.6M

OSF official SA spend

1997 to 2023

73+

OSF-funded organisations

verified primary sources

$29M

Constitutionalism Fund

OSF + Ford + Atlantic

~$47M

MAVC programme

USAID + Omidyar + DFID

SCAN FOR LIVE INTERACTIVE DATABASE

https://altafrikaner.github.io/journalist-map/osf-funded-orgs.html

Searchable database of 100+ organisations, overlap matrix, sector charts, architecture diagrams and live primary source links.

1. THREE DIFFERENT FUNDERS, OVERLAPPING FIELDS

Open Society Foundations / OSF-SA

Private philanthropy, founded by George Soros

OSF established its South African foundation in 1993, during South Africa's transition to democracy. Its own 2025 retrospective confirms $238,635,789 invested 1997 to 2023, supporting roughly 1,000 organisations and individuals. OSF-SA was wound up in the 2021 to 2023 consolidation into Open Society-Africa; OSF says support for South Africa continues.

Focus: institution building, public-interest law, constitutionalism, accountability, independent media, gender and health, criminal justice. Long-term core funding.

Omidyar Network / Luminate

Private philanthropy, Pierre and Pam Omidyar

In 2018, the governance and civic engagement portfolio became Luminate. South Africa is explicitly named as a Luminate priority country. Sub-entities: Imaginable Futures (education) and Flourish Ventures (fintech). The SA portfolio concentrates heavily in the information and media layer where OSF also operates.

Focus: digital media, investigative journalism, civic technology, open data, fact-checking, information integrity, citizen mobilisation.

USAID

U.S. government, subject to congressional oversight

Unlike the first two, USAID is government-funded. SA democracy and governance programmes have historically sought to strengthen civil society and accountability. USAID does not mirror Luminate's SA portfolio exactly: its strongest overlaps occur through implementation and through the Making All Voices Count joint programme.

Focus: governance and accountability, health, gender and GBV, violence prevention, capacity building, technology for governance.

Key qualification: The evidence proves co-funding, common vehicles and overlapping recipient institutions. It does not, by itself, prove that donors jointly dictate editorial positions, that one donor controls another, or that receiving money means a particular output was donor-directed. Those questions require grant agreements, scopes of work, restricted-versus-core grant conditions, programme memoranda and correspondence that are not yet publicly available.

2. KEY FINDINGS

$238,635,789

OSF official SA total

Disclosed in OSF's 30-year retrospective (March 2025). First time the full cumulative figure has been officially released. Excludes the original $15 million endowment.

3 channels

Stacked funding confirmed

amaBhungane recorded OSF-SA R812,942, CF-AOSI R842,211 and Luminate R2,124,677 simultaneously in its FY2023 audited accounts.

SAMIP

Formal private donor bridge

MDIF's 2017 announcement: SAMIP was initiated by OSF-SA, funded by Omidyar Network and managed by MDIF. Not a coincidental overlap: a deliberately constructed joint programme.

MAVC

Documented three-way convergence

The MAVC Strategy Synthesis names OSF alongside USAID, Omidyar, DFID and Sida. Hivos's 2014 report calls OSF a key architect of the $47M programme.

200+

CF grantees undisclosed

The Constitutionalism Fund states more than 200 organisations received funding. Only 65 are named publicly. The full downstream network remains partially unknown.

$29M

CF second-degree channel

The CF adds a funding rail rather than replacing direct OSF grants. ProBono.Org received CF R2M and OSF R1.3M in the same year, confirmed from audited accounts.

3. WHERE THE FUNDERS FORMALLY MEET

The most important finding is not coincidental overlap. It is where distinct funders deliberately built or participated in joint funding programmes. 'Two donors separately funding the same NGO' and 'co-investors in the same funding programme' are not equivalent findings.

SAMIP

OSF-SA + Omidyar Network (later Luminate), managed by MDIF, 2017 to present

MDIF's 2017 announcement: SAMIP was initiated by OSF-SA, Omidyar Network provided funding support, and MDIF managed the programme. Its purpose was funding and capacity-building for independent South African media. After Omidyar's governance portfolio became Luminate, SAMIP identified its funders as OSF-SA and Luminate. Media recipients include Daily Maverick and community news ventures.

MAVC

USAID $10M + Omidyar + DFID + Sida. OSF documented in early programme materials

The MAVC Strategy Synthesis explicitly names OSF alongside USAID, Omidyar, DFID and Sida. Hivos's 2013 report records OSF contributing at least 1.5 million euros; Hivos's 2014 report calls OSF a key architect of MAVC. USAID contributed $10M (USAID evaluation). The current MAVC archive omits OSF; the earlier programme documents are the stronger sources. OpenUp and amandla.mobi both received MAVC support.

Constitutionalism Fund

OSF + Ford + Atlantic, $29M, 2015 to 2025 formal lifespan

CF's own homepage confirms: a US$29 million joint investment established in 2015 by Atlantic Philanthropies, Ford Foundation and Open Society Foundation. OSF-SA initially administered the fund; AOSI was fiscal sponsor. Later, Ford took administration and New Venture Fund became fiscal sponsor as the Ford Foundation Dignity and Justice Fund, South Africa Constitutionalism Initiative. GroundUp's 2025 audited accounts name this NVF channel explicitly. amandla.mobi still lists CF via NVF as a 2026 funder.

First CF cohort, 2016: 12 organisations pre-selected from existing Atlantic and OSF trusted grantees (source: LRC 2015/16 Annual Report):

Black Sash	**Equal Education**	**Legal Resources Centre**	**Centre for Applied Legal Studies**
Centre for Law and Society	**Centre for Child Law**	**Lawyers for Human Rights**	**SECTION27**
SERI	**Ndifuna Ukwazi**	**ProBono.Org**	**Social Justice Coalition**

4. STACKED FUNDING: CONFIRMED FROM AUDITED ACCOUNTS

The Constitutionalism Fund is not replacing direct OSF funding. It is an additional funding rail. The following are confirmed from recipients' own published audited financial statements, not estimates. Source codes refer to the source list on page 7.

Organisation	Pooled / CF channel	Direct or parallel funding	Ref
ProBono.Org, 2018	CF R2,000,000	OSF-SA R1,303,000	S1
ProBono.Org, 2019	CF R1,500,000	OSF R800,000	S1
amaBhungane, FY2023	CF-AOSI R842,211	OSF-SA R812,942 plus Luminate R2,124,677	S2
Open Secrets, 2023	none listed	OSF-HRI R1.42M plus OSF-SA R1.52M plus Luminate R3.67M	S3
PARI, 2025	CF listed	OSF South Africa listed and Ford Foundation listed	S4
Centre for Child Law, 2016	CF R700,000	Direct OSF R750,000	S5
amandla.mobi, 2024 to 2026	CF via NVF	Luminate ongoing	S6
GroundUp, 2023 to 2025	CF/NVF R1.9M plus R1.8M	No separate direct OSF listed	S7

Qualification: simultaneous funding through distinct but overlapping channels does not prove grants financed the same activity, or that any donor directed the other's output.

5. VERIFIED AMOUNTS

Different amount types are not directly comparable. System-level programme totals, organisation-level direct grants and investment or guarantee instruments are presented in separate tiers below.

Tier A: System-level programme totals

$238,635,789

OSF official SA spend, 1997 to 2023

OSF 30-year retrospective, March 2025

$29 million

Constitutionalism Fund total

Atlantic $10M verified; OSF and Ford reported. CF own homepage.

approx $47M

Making All Voices Count programme

USAID contributed $10M. MAVC programme documents name OSF also.

Tier B: Organisation-level grants, confirmed from primary sources

Organisation	Amount	Source
ISS, Open Society Foundations global	$5.1 million across 7 grants	S8
UCT, Open Society Foundations global	$2.6 million across 7 grants	S8
amaBhungane, Luminate	$625,000 total (2020 to 2025)	S9
amaBhungane, all channels FY2023	R3,779,852 across three channels	S2
ProBono.Org, direct OSF, five years	R800K + R230K + R569K + R800K + R400K	S1
OpenUp, Luminate	$1,920,189 total committed	S10
SmartStart, Omidyar	$1,100,000 ($500K in 2019, $600K in 2021)	S11
D.G. Murray Trust, Omidyar	$1,050,000	S12
Digital Frontiers Institute, Omidyar	$764,000	S12
Open Secrets, Luminate, 2022/23	R3,671,463 in audited accounts	S3
Sonke Gender Justice, OSF	R1.22M (2023), R1.55M (2022)	S13
African Leadership Academy, Omidyar	$1.5M (2011) plus $1.5M (2017)	S14
Black Stripe Foundation, Omidyar and Luminate	$683,000 total	S11
IBP-SA, Luminate	$500,000	S10
Futurelect, Luminate	$450,000 total committed	S10
Wikimedia South Africa, OSF-SA	R200,000 bridge funding, 2013	S15
OSF frontline activist fund, SAHRDN	$330,000, 2019	S16
SA Solidarity Fund, OSF	approx $270,250, 2020	S17

Tier C: Investment and guarantee instruments (not equivalent to grants)

Instrument	Amount / Structure	Note	Ref
NURCHA, OSF	$5M operating support plus $50M guarantee facility, 1995 to 2015	OSF own reports. NURCHA is a development finance institution; the guarantee is not a direct grant.	S18
littlefish, Flourish Ventures	$9.5M Series A investment, 2026	Equity investment by Flourish Ventures (Omidyar fintech sub-entity). littlefish is a for-profit company.	S19
SPARK Schools, Imaginable Futures	Series C participation, 2021	Imaginable Futures held existing SPARK shares at Series C. Amount not publicly disclosed.	S20
Zlto, Imaginable Futures	Investment amount not disclosed	Imaginable Futures explicitly confirmed the investment. Zlto is a for-profit NPO structure.	S21

6. NETWORK OVERLAP MATRIX: 15 KEY ORGANISATIONS

Symbol key: D = Direct documented funding, P = Pooled or programme funding, H = Historical or institutional (older records), n/v = not yet verified in primary sources (does not mean never funded).

Organisation / sector	OSF / OSF-SA	Omidyar / Luminate	USAID	CF / Pooled
amaBhungane, investigative journalism	D	D	n/v	D (AOSI)
amandla.mobi, digital mobilisation	D (2016 to 2022)	D (2018 onward)	P (MAVC)	D (NVF 2024+)
OpenUp / Code for SA, civic tech	D	D ($1.92M)	P (MAVC)	n/v
Open Secrets, economic crime	D	D	n/v	n/v
Africa Check, fact-checking	D (12% income)	D (8% income)	n/v	n/v
Right2Know, information rights	D (seeded)	D (2019 to 2021)	n/v	n/v
MMA / Moxii, media monitoring	D ($200K 2023)	D (investee)	n/v*	n/v
Daily Maverick, journalism	D (current)	P (SAMIP)	n/v	n/v
GroundUp, public-interest journalism	D (historical)	n/v	n/v	D (NVF)
Corruption Watch, anti-corruption	D	n/v	n/v	D
Sonke Gender Justice, gender	D	n/v	D (APC programme)	n/v
CSVR, violence and reconciliation	D	n/v	D (AID-674-A-14-00016)	n/v
PMG, parliamentary monitoring	H	n/v	H (OSF study)	n/v
ProBono.Org, access to justice	D	n/v	n/v	D (2016 cohort)
Legal Resources Centre, litigation	D (R500K to R1.1M/yr)	n/v	n/v	D (2016 cohort)

** No evidence strong enough to label MMA a USAID recipient has been verified.*

APPENDIX A: CORRECTION LOG (from earlier versions)

This investigation maintains a public correction log. Significant corrections applied between draft versions are listed below.

Item	Earlier version	Corrected version
Title	The Soros Network in South Africa	The Open Society Funding Network in South Africa
ALA funding total	$53.2M across three rounds	$3M+ (two confirmed ON grants). $53.2M figure conflated ALA (SA nonprofit) with ALU (separate for-profit, Mauritius and Rwanda)

Item	Earlier version	Corrected version
SPARK investment round	Series B 2021	Series C 2021: Imaginable Futures was an existing SPARK shareholder at Series C alongside Creadev and Finnfund
Meta/IFCN wording	Described as active global standard without qualification	Updated: Meta ended third-party fact-checking in the US in January 2025; international transition proceeds separately
Language silo claim	'Zero connections' for Afrikaans press	'Substantially fewer documented connections': the stronger absolute claim requires systematic mapping methodology
CF classification	'Second-degree conduit' implying concealment	'Pooled-fund intermediary': CF architecture is publicly disclosed
CF dates	1997 to 2025	2015 to 2025: CF was established in 2015, not 1997
Real411 demographic claim	Described as targeting primarily Afrikaner content	Removed: complaint dataset has not been published or independently analysed
USAID	Entirely absent from earlier versions	Now included as full third funding network throughout
OSF founding year context	'1993, the first year of democracy'	'1993, during South Africa's transition to democracy': first democratic election was in 1994
Data columns	renderOSF() and renderOmid() columns shifted one position left	Corrected: all column mappings verified against data array structure
Wording	'From the same network of funders'	'Through distinct but overlapping funding channels': the three funders are not proved to form one controlled network

7. PRIMARY SOURCES

Foundation records and retrospectives

[S17] OSF 30-Year South Africa Retrospective (March 2025). $238,635,789 official total; 1,000+ organisations and individuals. Source of the founding-year history.

[S15] OSF 25-Year SA Release (November 2018). CF, SAMIP, Social Auditing Network and Right2Know seed funding explicitly credited.

[S18] OSF own reports: NURCHA partnership, $5M operating support plus $50M guarantee.

[S16] OSF press release, November 2019. $330,000 frontline activist fund hosted at SAHRDN.

[S10] Luminate investee database (September 2026). OpenUp $1.92M; Futurelect $450K; Wits Foundation CTIN grants confirmed.

[S19] Flourish Ventures website (2026). littlefish $9.5M Series A confirmed.

[S21] Imaginable Futures. Zlto investment explicitly stated.

Form 990-PF filings

[S11] Omidyar Network Fund Form 990-PF 2017. South African grants: ALA $1.5M, Black Stripe $283K, IkamvaYouth $311K, Bluestream $70K, Grass Root Nation $90K.

[S12] Omidyar Network Fund Form 990-PF 2018. D.G. Murray Trust $1.05M; Digital Frontiers Institute $764K.

[S11] Luminate Foundation Form 990-PF 2021. Africa Check; amaBhungane; amandla.mobi; Black Stripe $200K.

[S22] Ford Foundation Form 990-PF 2021. $4M to AOSI for Core Support, Constitutionalism Fund.

Recipient audited financial statements

[S1] ProBono.Org Annual Reports 2018 and 2019. CF plus OSF simultaneously; strongest stacked-funding proof in dataset.

[S2] amaBhungane Audited AFS FY2023 and FY2025. Triple-channel stacked funding; CF-AOSI still active in FY2025.

[S3] Open Secrets Annual Report 2022/23. Luminate R3,671,463.

[S13] Sonke Gender Justice Audited AFS 2023. OSF R1.22M confirmed.

[S7] GroundUp Audited AFS 2025. 'New Venture Fund: Ford Foundation Dignity and Justice Fund, South Africa Constitutionalism Initiative.'

[S9] amaBhungane Declarations (May 2025). Luminate grant history.

Programme documents

[S6] amandla.mobi Funding Disclosure page (updated 2024). All channels confirmed.

[S4] PARI Brochure, February 2025. CF plus Ford plus OSF listed as current funders.

[S5] Centre for Child Law Annual Report 2016. CF R700,000 plus OSF R750,000 simultaneously.

[S23] MAVC Strategy Synthesis. Names OSF alongside USAID, Omidyar, DFID and Sida.

[S24] Hivos Annual Reports 2013 and 2014. OSF at least 1.5 million euros to MAVC; OSF called key architect.

[S25] MDIF press release 2017. SAMIP initiated by OSF-SA, funded by Omidyar Network.

[S26] LRC 2015/16 Annual Report. Names all 12 first CF cohort members.

Government and institutional records

[S27] USAID OIG audit, AID-674-A-14-00016. USAID resources managed by CSVR confirmed.

[S8] Devex, June 2025. OSF five-year Global South analysis: ISS $5.1M, UCT $2.6M.

[S28] OSF-SA own website (osf.org.za). M&G; 200 Young SA 2018 grantee feature: confirms SWEAT, Sonke, SOS Coalition, WJP, CCL, CER and ACMS as direct OSF-SA grantees.

[S14] PR Newswire 2011. Omidyar Network commits $1.5M to ALA (South African nonprofit). Note: $53.2M figure belongs to ALU (separate for-profit entity in Mauritius and Rwanda).

[S20] Finnfund 2021. SPARK Schools Series C: Imaginable Futures as existing shareholder.

[S29] Cornell University Archives. OSF-SA grant files 2009 to 2014: Section27, Equal Education, SJC, SERI cluster grants confirmed.

VIEW FULL INTERACTIVE DATABASE ONLINE

https://altafrikaner.github.io/journalist-map/osf-funded-orgs.html

Searchable by sector, funding track, verification status. Overlap matrix. Sector charts.